eight and the Test ended in a draw. Faf remained unbeaten at the end, having scored 110 runs in just under eight hours – a heroic debut.

It may seem odd but, in cricket, a Test match saved can feel as satisfying as a Test match won, and as we travelled to play the third and final Test in Perth there was new optimism in our squad.

Quietly, privately, however, I was becoming concerned, starting to doubt myself. I knew I had played my part in Adelaide, but I had only once scored more than 50 since the tour to New Zealand, and one half-century in 19 innings or one half-century in eight months was not good enough. People were starting to suggest that keeping wicket was having a negative effect on my batting. People were wondering whether I would be dropped.

I began to worry. Should I tell coach Gary Kirsten that I didn't want to keep wicket because it was causing spasms in my lower back and because I wanted to concentrate on my batting? Or should I set aside my personal priorities and continue to keep wicket because the coach and captain felt it was in the best interests of the team?

My decision was never in doubt because the team means everything to me and, by nature, I want to keep people happy. So I decided to keep my concerns to myself and to keep wicket in the decider at the WACA. The reality was that, whether or not I kept wicket, I urgently needed to score some runs.

We won the toss and batted, and were soon struggling at 75 for six. I was caught in the slips for four, but Faf continued his outstanding form and his unbeaten 78 helped us reach a respectable total of 225. We needed to bowl well to stay in the Test, and it was Dale who met the challenge, dismissing four of the top six Australian batsmen. In trouble at 45 for six, they partially recovered to reach 163 all out, but the Test hung in the balance.

After so many sessions spent swimming against the tide in this series, so many demanding days spent fighting hard to stay in contention, we